U.S. NONPROFIT SAFEGUARDING
Crosswalk Project

Safeguarding Quick Start

Six basic safeguards for nonprofits that serve people directly — a two-page starting point

Pilot draft, October 2026 · Free under CC BY 4.0 · Not legal advice · info@pseacrosswalk.org

Nonprofits help people who often have nowhere else to turn — for food, shelter, counseling, or a mentor for their child. That dependence gives an organization's staff and volunteers a kind of power over the people they serve. Safeguarding is how an organization makes sure that power is not misused by its own people — and what it does when someone raises a concern.

Outside a few licensed settings, no U.S. law requires a nonprofit to have these protections in place; each organization decides for itself. In a 2026 review of 100 Washington nonprofits that serve people directly, 66 showed none of the six basic safeguards below on their websites. Each safeguard below points to the free template that sets it up; **$0** means no spending, only staff or volunteer time.

Safeguard	What it looks like in practice	Where to find it
1. A written policy $0	A short policy, adopted by your board, that says the organization protects the people it serves from exploitation, abuse, and harassment by its own personnel — and how. *Example: a food bank's board adopts a four-section starter policy at one meeting.*	Tool 1 — Sections 1–3 and 6 (starter) or 1–9 (full); adoption, Section 10
2. Clear rules of conduct $0	Written rules every staff member and volunteer signs: no sexual contact with participants, nothing exchanged for help, no private contact with children outside the program — in person or online. *Example: a mentoring program adds "no one-to-one texting with a youth participant outside the program's own channel."*	Tool 1 — Section 3 (rules 3.1–3.7); signed acknowledgment, 4.3
3. A visible way to raise a concern $0	At least two ways for a participant, a parent, or a staff member to report a concern — one that does not go through the person providing their services — posted where services happen, in the languages participants use; anonymous reports accepted. *Example: a notice at intake with a name, a phone number, and an email.*	Tool 1 — Section 6; Annex A (a channel people use); Annex B (Participant Charter)
4. Background checks for contact roles (fees may apply for criminal history checks)	Before anyone starts a role with unsupervised or recurring contact with participants: a free check of the National Sex Offender Public Website (NSOPW.gov), two reference checks that ask directly about safeguarding concerns, and the criminal history check your state or funders require. *Example: a shelter asks every reference: "Any concern about this person working with vulnerable adults?"*	Tool 1 — Section 4
5. Training $0	A one-hour orientation your own staff deliver before anyone starts: the rules, the warning signs, how to report. A short refresher once a year. *Example: a 60-minute session at the next volunteer onboarding.*	Tool 4 — Session 1 (60 min); Session 2 refresher (45 min); 3-minute intake script

Safeguard	What it looks like in practice	Where to find it
6. A named lead — and an alternate $0	One person the board designates, in writing, to receive and act on concerns — including a report about a manager — and an alternate for concerns about that person or the executive director. *Example: the program director as Focal Point and a board member as alternate.*	Tool 1 — Section 6.1

Where do you stand? Six questions

Answer yes only if it is true today and you could show it — a document, a signed form, a posted notice.

	Question	Yes	No
1	Has your board adopted a written policy that covers how personnel treat the people you serve — not only how employees treat each other?	☐	☐
2	Does every staff member and volunteer sign rules of conduct toward participants?	☐	☐
3	Can a participant raise a concern without going through the person who provides their services — and is that way posted where services happen?	☐	☐
4	Is everyone in a contact role screened before they start — NSOPW.gov, two references, and the criminal history check your state or funders require?	☐	☐
5	Does every new staff member and volunteer get safeguarding orientation before they begin?	☐	☐
6	Has the board named, in writing, a lead and an alternate to receive concerns?	☐	☐

Six yes: run the full 32-indicator Self-Assessment (Tool 2, about an hour) to find the gaps this page does not cover — response procedures, partner organizations, records, and the annual review. **Any no:** start with the first one. A very small, all-volunteer organization can decide all six at one board meeting and put them in place within its first 90 days.

What this page is not

These six safeguards are a starting point — not a complete safeguarding system, and not a determination of legal compliance. The full toolkit (four free tools, CC BY 4.0) adds what the six leave out: how to respond to a report, external reporting to state authorities, requirements for partner organizations, records, and an annual review. Nothing here is legal advice: have your completed policy reviewed by counsel licensed in your state, and check your state's mandatory-reporting and background-check laws, which this page does not replace.

Help us make this useful

We are testing this page with a small number of organizations before publishing it. If you work at a nonprofit, twenty minutes of your reaction — what would work in your organization, what would not, and what is missing — will shape the next version. Write to info@pseacrosswalk.org, or ask for a call.

Free toolkit: https://pseacrosswalk.org/toolkit.html · **Research:** *Safeguarding Without a Baseline* (Module 1, open-access working paper): https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22022939 · *Washington Safeguarding Baseline 2026* (publicly released report): pseacrosswalk.org/baseline-2026.html